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Vince Lateano

Drummer Vince Lateano was born in Sacramento, California. He was performing professionally while still in his teens and settled in San Francisco after military service. Vince has recorded and toured with a lengthy list of jazz luminaries including Vince Guaraldi, Woody Herman, Tania Maria and Cal Tjader. He has been a drum instructor for the Monterey Jazz Festival since 1983.

Vince was interviewed in San Francisco, California on August 8, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in San Francisco. I'm pleased to have drummer Vince Lateano with me today. You know, when you come into town and you look at the local papers and stuff, it looks like there is a very active jazz scene here. But I wonder if it's like that all the time.

VL: Well people say that. They come in and just like what you're saying, it can be deceiving. There is an active jazz scene. First I should say that. I mean there are a lot of people here that make their living playing jazz. But the listings sometimes, you have several listings and it might be music in a restaurant, which could be jazz but also could be wallpaper. And we've all been there, and there is a difference. I say the same thing, I have a friend that lives in Los Angeles and I've seen the Los Angeles newspaper and I say man, there's really a lot going on. He says well, I don't know. He says the same thing. But it's a vibrant scene, I mean you can make a living here.

MR: That's saying something.

VL: Exactly. That's why I'm here. Because when I moved here, oh 35 years ago I guess, '66, I was on my way somewhere else. I mean I'd just got out of the service you know, I was visiting friends here and I thought well I'll go to L.A. or New York, I mean that's where the music business is. And I got here and I just started hanging out and playing and I thought, you know I really like the climate and the town and the people, it just really appeals to me. And I just kept staying here and staying here and here I am. But I hooked up with bands and traveled and everything. So you can make a living here.

MR: What's a typical week like for you in this area? I mean most musicians need to do a lot of different things. Is that the case for you?

VL: Yes. I'm fortunate in that I've been involved in this one little club called Jazz at Pearl's which is the local jazz club — by local, they use local musicians. It's not like Yoshi's across the Bay is the national, or the international club. People come from all over the world to play Yoshi's. But Jazz at Pearl's is our little neighborhood jazz club and I came with the place twelve years ago. So you've probably — that's why you've seen my name.

MR: I think I've seen your name.

VL: I'm there three nights a week. He just gave it to me. You know I started out, I worked for this Sonny Buxton, who is somebody you should talk to I think maybe. Anyway Sonny is a very interesting man. He had a former club called Milestones. I worked there. And when he and Pearl Wong opened this club twelve years ago they didn't know what they were going to do on weeknights. On weekends they knew what they wanted to do. So I started playing, taking a little trio in there on weeknights. And it was sort of week to week. And then after a few weeks or months he just said why don't you just let me know when you can't be here.

MR: Oh I like those kind of gigs. I have one at home actually.

VL: Oh yeah? You know what I'm talking about. I mean and so I did it with Bruce Forman, a great guitarist for several years because we were neighbors. And then he left the area, he's now living in Carmel Valley. So he's not available. And I had another piano player right after him for several years. So in other words I had the same guys. And then Al Plank is this piano player, this wonderful musician. And he had some surgery last I guess December and he's recovered but he just doesn't want to do anything right now. He's just kind of taking a little hiatus. So I've been using different people, or I should say the club owner books different people. So every night I'll walk in and play with a different piano player or guitar player. And there's like a pool of people. And so it's very interesting. I get the bass player and it's right down the street from my house, you know I've kind of died and went to Birdland.

MR: Great. I'll have to see if I can get in there before we leave here.

VL: Yes.

MR: It's probably close to this area.

VL: Yeah it's Columbus Avenue. You go I guess it would be west — or east rather — you go the other way. And it's right near the heart of North Beach.

MR: Great. In reading your bio it looks like you were influenced by a musical family, not your own?

VL: Right. I grew up in Sacramento, which is not far from here, and there was a family in the neighborhood, the father had done some conducting in Hollywood and so on and so forth, and they'd moved up and they had a couple of brothers and a daughter, a sister. And they were all involved. And we used to have rehearsals and they were — just right down the street. So when I was very small I would sit outside and watch them rehearse. And I went wow, I've got to figure this out. This is — I'm talking about preschool, you know, four and five, just hearing this music. And my family, my immediate family, they weren't musicians but they liked to have a good time. And so I got to hear a lot of music. And then the California State Fair was like near my house so every summer everybody would

come through there and play. So I heard a lot of live music. And I was inspired by that, to do something. I played the trumpet first. And I switched to drums when I was in high school. And I don't know, plus public schools in those days, we're talking the fifties, were — I'm making a living on what I learned in public schools. I mean I didn't go to college. I mean I started college and it lasted about a month, I couldn't stand it. I had to go. That's with the Carmen Cavallaro thing. He had popped up so I grabbed it just to get out of town.

MR: Really.

VL: And I mean but it was a good gig. It was a demanding gig. I learned a lot and I saw the country.

MR: You were only 18 at the time?

VL: Yeah. I was 18 at the time.

MR: What did your parents think about that?

VL: Well they were very supportive. They were blue collar people. They tried to warn me of the pitfalls and they were right. They said that's a pretty rough way to make a living. You know, what are you going to do when there's no work, and so forth, and job security and so forth. And I said I don't know. And we all go through that. And they were right. And it's the same. There's work and there's no work. But you have to learn to deal with it and it's not for everybody. You know. You're a musician.

MR: I'm a musician.

VL: What do you play?

MR: I'm a saxophone player.

VL: All right.

MR: I do lots of things too you know.

VL: Well I mean you asked me about doing other things, and I've sort of avoided the teaching per se. I mean I give an occasional lesson but I don't have a stable of students or a place. But I am involved and I have been since its inception for twenty years now, in the Monterey Jazz Festival has a jazz educational program that was started oh around '83 I guess or '84. Jimmy Lyons, who ran the festival for so many years, he and the then-musical director Mundell Lowe got the idea to put music education in Monterey County which is the home of the Monterey Jazz Festival, as a give back, as a gift. So they started with three clinicians: myself, Bill Berry — have you talked to Bill Berry?

MR: Yeah.

VL: Isn't he great?

MR: What a nice guy.

VL: Oh yeah, he's great. I love Bill Berry. Bill Berry, myself and a very fine musician from the Santa Cruz area named Paul Contos, a reed player, very good. The three of us started.

And when they tapped me I had worked the festival a few times with Cal Tjader and some other people. And so Jimmy says, "You want to do this thing?" And I said, "I'm not a teacher, I wouldn't know where to begin." I mean it's true, I mean you need an educator. He said, "Nope, Mundell said we want players just to go in and impart your experience." I said, "Okay I'll try it." Twenty years later, you know? It's fun. I enjoy that. I really do.

MR: Well I think it's an important thing that teachers of jazz — and I suppose you could say this about anything, but especially of jazz, ought to be players first. And I'm not sure that's the norm anymore in the universities.

VL: Well universities I don't know. I don't spend much time in universities. I go in to just middle schools and high schools, and band directors at most of these places are not jazz musicians. But the high school I went to, the band director was not a jazz musician but he was a good musician and he was very open and he encouraged myself, Rufus Reid, he was a year behind me, Mel Martin — I don't know if you talked to Mel — and a few other guys that have made a living playing music, went to this school and were lucky enough to be under the tutelage of this man, Aubrey Pennyman, and he wasn't a jazz musician but he gave us our head. He said, "What do you want to do?" So it can work. But it helps. I wish, like we go into a school and while the band's rehearsing, and I sidle up next to the drummers and just make friends and they play and then I'll point something out on the chart or the equipment or it's like a real hands on, like an hour thing. It's not a one-on-one private lesson. And then all the time I'm giving him some pointers or I demonstrate. And I wish somebody had done that for me. I mean I didn't have that benefit. I had to really go find places to watch musicians play.

MR: Did you choose to go in the service?

VL: Well I was drafted. It was pre — it was 1963. In fact, I was thinking about that today. Today is August the 8th, and it's Benny Carter's 95th birthday, which is — I played with Benny Carter twice and — my idol you know. But today I thought August the 8th, that's the day I got drafted many, many years ago.

MR: '63.

VL: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

VL: Yeah. And so I mean in those days it was like I said pre-Vietnam when the stuff really hit the fan. And so there was no thought of resisting. People got drafted and you hoped you didn't get drafted, but I ended up in a band and it wasn't that bad. I practiced a lot.

MR: Most musicians that I've talked to have been fortunate in that they ended up in some kind of band.

VL: Yeah. Well the thing is you have an option. If you enlist you can pick your station — or you could then, you could pick a band and a station if you qualified. And if you get drafted it's the luck of the draw. So if you enlist it's three years and if you get drafted it's two years so I just said I'll just take my chances. So I ended up in a band. And it was okay. It was still the Army.

MR: Marching and so on?

VL: Oh yeah. Yeah. Like I say if somebody says were you in the service, I say yeah, our side. I fought and I fought and they took me anyway.

MR: So after you got out and you're surveying the scene and you ended up here and what was your first I guess break that you might call it?

VL: After I'd moved here?

MR: Yeah.

VL: I started — you move someplace and you're at the bottom of the list. Because I didn't know that many people here. And I guess I started playing with Vince Guaraldi sort of immediately after I wasn't here that long and I started doing some stuff with him. And that helped. I didn't play on a regular basis but I used to play — he'd change things around, he was trying different stuff.

MR: Was this — I'm trying to remember when he had his kind of hit with "Cast Your Fate to the Wind."

VL: Oh this was after that, yeah.

MR: It was after that.

VL: Yeah. "Cast Your Fate" I think happened in the early 60s, like maybe '61 or '62 or 3, right in there. And I wasn't here yet. So yeah, he was already on the map. He was a favorite around here. And then when I got with him he was doing the Charlie Brown stuff. And in fact I did one of those, I did a TV — I think it's called "The Charlie Brown Valentine Special" or something like that. We did that.

MR: So if you were to watch that on TV you'd be listening to yourself?

VL: Yeah, yeah, yeah. And Vince, he was a character. And he was a good musician and I got to do that for a while, and associating with somebody like that it puts your name out there. So that was probably the first. And then I got in with a guy, the guy that's doing all the work here, a real good drummer named John Markham, he's deceased now, and he was like a big band drummer but he could do everything. And he was, at that time he was working with Frank Sinatra when Sinatra was going out of town, and so he heard me play somewhere and I started subbing for him. And so that helped. And that's the way it is in music. You just go and you just get in line and start appearing and trying to get your foot in the door to get work. Because you've got to work.

MR: What would a typical club date have paid in the mid 60s and late 60s in this area?

VL: Oh God. Well what you call a club date we call a casual. Is that what you're talking about? Other than a club date. Or what do they call it in Boston? A general business?

MR: They do?

VL: Yeah. GB or something like that?

MR: Oh I hadn't heard that.

VL: Yeah. Anyway God I don't know, let's put it this way. When I moved here in '66 my rent was $75 a month.

MR: I bet it's not that now.

VL: No it isn't. Woo this town is brutal.

MR: I heard it's like the second highest in the country.

VL: I'm sure it is. Yeah. It's not for everybody. You've got to really want to live here.

MR: Uh huh.

VL: Yeah.

MR: Okay. But at that time if you made 50 bucks on a date.

VL: Yeah, it was probably something like that. Yeah.

MR: I see you worked with Woody Herman.

VL: Briefly, yeah.

MR: And Sal Nistico was on the band.

VL: Yeah.

MR: God, what a monstrous player.

VL: Oh he was a wonderful musician, and a great guy. I really treasure that moment, that little bit of time where we got to — and then we remained friends and whenever he came through town, like he was here with oh a couple of different people, he was here with Tito Puente once, he was here with Gap Mangione in a little band. Different bands. And we'd always get together and hang out. I miss him. He was a great guy, a great player.

MR: Do you consider yourself a big band drummer?

VL: Yeah. I mean actually I did it, I mean that was part of my experience and training coming up, and a lot of the gigs we did, casuals or club dates, had to do with big bands, so that was a skill that was valuable. And I sort of spent some time at it. And then I didn't do it for a long time, there weren't any gigs and I stopped making rehearsal bands and stuff like that. And then this club Pearl's where I work has a Monday Night Big Band and I used to sub in that once in a while. And now I'm kind of doing it on a regular basis. I'm really enjoying it. Of course the band plays a lot of Thad Jones material and Oliver Nelson material, and Frank Foster and stuff like that so it's all fun to play. And I guess because I've been doing it a long time and I'm just better at it, at least I think so.

MR: Well who were the people that influenced you, drummers, along the way?

VL: Well in the big bands, when I was in high school, that was when I first started playing, I was really drawn to big bands and the Kenton band and of course Basie and Duke, all those guys. Sonny Payne, I remember seeing him when I was just starting out and I was just floored. I thought he was —

MR: He had a lot of style, didn't he?

VL: Oh he was just — I mean he had it all, you know, for a big band. I mean he was just so dynamic. Here this band is just quietly steaming along and all of a sudden it explodes right in front of your eyes. It would just like — when you're a kid especially it would just throw you back. And then he was just so much fun to watch. And I don't play anything like that. But he knocked me out. And of course then later on Shelly Manne and Mel Lewis and Woodyard, who I loved, Sam Woodyard. You know, that kind of thing. And then I started listening to all kinds of — I got more into Blakey and Max and Philly Joe and Roy Haynes and those guys. And there are just so many guys. And then all the new guys that come along, it just gets better and better technically.

MR: Right. What's it like trying to absorb the Latin end of things? Because I know you've worked with Cal Tjader.

VL: With Cal Tjader. Yeah. Well that was a piece of luck because I was thrown in with Poncho Sanchez and a mutual friend of Cal's and mine was a great musician/drummer/vibist John Rae. And he'd worked with Cal and he'd worked with Vince Guaraldi and Herbie Mann. He lived out here but he was originally from Boston and spent a lot of time in New York, he'd played with Shearing — played vibes with Shearing — a great musician. And he's gone. And anyway we were good friends and he told me Cal was looking for somebody, "Do you want to do it?" And I said well I'd had a little Latin experience, but I'm a jazz drummer that plays Latin music, I'm not a Latin drummer. But you had to do both with Cal. He used to say it's like turning a little switch in your mind, you know, you sit down, you play one style of music, he liked jazz, maybe Philly Joe or something, and then as soon as you start playing the other thing it was kind of like a Tito Puente, that was his frame of reference. And so I had a little knowledge going in. I had enough that it was accepted. And then Poncho was there and Poncho would just say "Yeah," "no," you know, when we're playing. You know, "Do that," "don't do that." So he helped me a lot. But like I said I'm still — compared to what's happening.

MR: If someone says playing merengue as opposed to, I don't know, a salsa beat, do you know what that means specifically?

VL: Um hum. Yeah.

MR: Okay. Because there are so many different categories.

VL: I do. There are a lot that I don't know I'm sure, but I found out that like it's regional. Of course Afro-Cuban, Cuba. And that big influence, you know, salsa. And then every country has its own groove. And I think the merengue came from Santo Domingo. So if you do a little research you'd find out each country had its way of doing things. Like the Cubans have a carnival, like all those countries, and when they go down the street they play a groove called the comparsa or Mozambique. And the Brazilians of course do samba. And it's very similar but it's different. So a little subtle understanding of that kind of thing helps.

MR: I actually have a piece of music to play here, and I suppose this could be like a blindfold test, but I wouldn't do that to you.

[audio interlude]

MR: This is actually you. I think it's you.

VL: Yeah. I recognize that. That's like sort of a bossa groove. [scats]

MR: This is from a video in San Diego.

VL: Yeah. I was with the band a month.

MR: You were just with them a month?

VL: Yeah I had just started with the band. That was '78. I joined Cal I guess around May of '78. And Clare Fischer, and Poncho, Rob Fisher, myself and Cal, and there was a great gig in San Diego, a place called the Catamaran in Mission Bay. It was like a musician's dream kind of gig, where you go and you're in a hotel sort of right on the water, it's a thing you fantasize about. And you come down the elevator and you go into the club and play.

MR: And then on breaks you can go back up to your room.

VL: Exactly, exactly. And it's just a kind of a great scene, yeah. And I did that quite a few times with Cal. And while we were there we went out to the college I think is where we did that, we went to a college, San Diego State or something like that. And they had a little studio and they had a sort of a mock nightclub, they had a few tables around where the camera could pick it up, and people sitting like at a club. And what I remember about that date was that they had me on a riser and there wasn't room for my floor tom, so I had — which was fine, I mean, you know, you don't need a lot of drums to get away with it. But it was like I kept trying to figure out how to move the drums — no I guess not, the hell with it. It's not going to happen.

MR: I guess the percussionist will play a little more tonight.

VL: Yeah. But that was a great experience, having played with those musicians. Because it rubs off. You're around them and —

MR: I didn't know that was Clare Fischer in that, playing the Fender Rhodes.

VL: Yeah he didn't like to play the piano.

MR: Really?

VL: Well he said there weren't any good pianos.

MR: Yeah okay. He didn't know what he was going to be playing?

VL: Did you ever talk to Clare?

MR: No.

VL: Oh you've got to talk to Clare.

MR: I'd love to, maybe you can — is he in L.A.?

VL: Yeah. Studio City, yeah. He's a brilliant musician/composer. I'll leave it right there.

MR: Okay. I can read between the lines that that would be interesting.

VL: Oh very.

MR: And Cal unfortunately, you were with him, playing with him when he passed away.

VL: Exactly. Almost four years to the day almost. He passed away in the Philippines in Manila on Cinco de Mayo, the fifth of May, in 1982. So I joined May '78, so four years. And that was a sad, tragic situation. We went — he was in the service during World War II. He was in the Navy and I think he was a Corpsman, a medical Corpsman. And he was in the Philippines towards the end of the war, and he sort of had an affinity for the place. In fact if you do any research, on his compositions he wrote tunes, "Mindanao," he wrote three or four tunes with Philippine island titles. So he'd been asked to go there a few times and sort of always put it off. And then his health wasn't good, when he decided to go, because they'd been asking him to go. And his wife didn't want him to go. But we went, and she went with him, and we got there, we didn't play a note. We got there, it was a long flight, we got there on an early Monday morning and he was restless and Tuesday he wasn't feeling good, and then Tuesday evening he went into a cardiac arrest and passed away the next day. So it was very, very unusual situation, to be that far away. And then we had to wait four or five days before we could all leave together, because we weren't leaving otherwise, without Cal, because of the bureaucratic thing. And it took a while to come back from that. You know? Plus he was a great, he was a wonderful guy. Funny, a good guy to work for, and obviously a good musician.

MR: One of the first to really popularize the kind of world music type.

VL: He was a pioneer, yeah, he was. He was working with George Shearing — Cal was from here, from the West Coast, he's from San Mateo, which is down the Peninsula. He and Merv Griffin went to prep school or high school together, so they were buddies. But anyway Cal, kind of a self-taught player, but worked with George Shearing for a while and while he was with George Shearing in New York, Al McKibbon was on the band and Al took him around the corner to the Palladium one night and he heard Tito Puente and Machito playing in a ballroom and flipped. And he just never heard anything like that he said. And so he got this idea that when he came back here after he left Shearing to put a

Latin jazz thing together, which is what he did. He had guys from here that could play both, because they had to play both ways. And then he said that they would barnstorm, where they would get in a car and go across the country and work all these places between here and New York where they had never heard anything like that, never heard Latin music. In fact he ran into some resistance in some places he said, they didn't want to hear that. And so he was a pioneer. Of course I think Dizzy was the first guy — or actually was it Mario Bauza, is he the guy that—

MR: He was with Dizzy, wasn't he?

VL: Well I think he was with Machito.

MR: Yeah, that's right.

VL: But I'm talking about Latin jazz. I think Dizzy with Chano Pozo was the first real jazz musician to cross over like that. But you know a guy you should talk to is John Santos. Has his name come up?

MR: No.

VL: He lives in the Bay area, he's a Latin musician, but he's a walking history book. He's a real interesting in the history of the music. But yeah, Cal was a pioneer, until I guess — I'm trying to think of what put him on the map. I guess "Soul Sauce/Guachi Guaro" was the first real national kind of hit in the early 60s. And I was with him in 1980, he won a Grammy. And I was on that record, which was sort of a —

MR: As a sideman on that record do you get anything?

VL: I got a hearty handshake.

MR: Yeah, right. It'd be nice if you got like a certificate or something.

VL: Well you know Carl Jefferson from Concord Records gave us each plaques.

MR: Yeah.

VL: You know.

MR: Okay.

VL: Commemoration. That's cool. Hey man, that's how it works, you know?

MR: Do you ever get — I don't know if royalties is the right word.

VL: That's the right word. No. I don't have any tunes, any publishing.

MR: Okay. But so just for playing on things you don't get it.

VL: Yeah. You get paid for the date.

MR: Right.

VL: I mean look at what the — Jimmy Cobb. You know? He's on probably the most famous jazz record in the world and I think he made a couple hundred bucks or something.

MR: Right. That is amazing to think of that.

VL: Yeah. Jimmy Cobb is another one of my favorites. Boy I love that guy.

MR: Re-issued and there've been books about it.

VL: I know. And movies.

MR: God. You can't eat fame though.

VL: You know I mean you sort of know that going in. I mean I guess some guys get bitter about it. But if your name isn't on the sign, I mean if you're not the leader, it's just like you know you contributed somehow, you were there, and your presence, but it just doesn't seem to work that way.

MR: Right. You've got an awful long list of people you've played with or recorded with and I just wondered about a few of them. Chet Baker?

VL: Well Chet was a gypsy. He'd come here and go there and do this and when he came to the Bay area, like a lot of people — another benefit of living here is that people do come through here and I get to play with them. But Chet was one of them. He was a character. A very good musician, very natural. I don't think he ever practiced or really worked at it. I think he just had it. I don't know. But he obviously had his — how do I put this — his agenda.

MR: His agenda.

VL: Yeah. And that was — I mean I saw him way down and way up. I mean I'll never forget one time we were playing a club here called Kimballs, a nice little club behind the Symphony Hall. And we met, we played a weekend, Friday and Saturday, and we met at 4:00 or something for a sound check get together, you know, one of those, rhythm section. So we show up, it's raining. And Chet shows up and he's got like an Army jacket on and some old cords and shower shoes. And he shows up and we gave him a, "You want to play the blues?" He says, "Oh great, I'll see you later." And that was fine, because he was very spontaneous. That was 4:00. We come back at 9:00 and he's sitting at the bar in the same outfit, you know in other words he hadn't gone anywhere. And he was a little wasted. And he apologized. And we said well you do what you gotta do, just don't fall off the stage. And the first set was pretty squirrelly. And it got better. And by the end of the night it was brilliant.

MR: Wow.

VL: You know? I mean it was like amazing, how anybody could pull that off. He might have had some help you know, but it was like going in and thinking oh this is going to be a disaster. People are waiting in the rain to come in, like because he — another thing about working with Chet was he had — people came to hear him that you never saw anywhere in a jazz club. You know what I mean?

MR: They wouldn't normally come out.

VL: I guess not. It was like a cult or something. It was like he had a different kind of a following. I mean the usual jazz fan that you've seen at other concerts might be there. But then there were always people that he sort of brought out. And the next night he shows up

in a suit and all dressed up and looking totally different. And he even gave us extra money at the end of it. So you never knew what to expect. But I liked playing with him. He really was so lyrical, so pretty.

MR: Sometimes it seems like the general audience likes their jazz musicians to be characters or somewhat tortured or something.

VL: I think so.

MR: Like we would never be like that but we like to see someone.

VL: Yeah right. And people listen with their eyes. And hopefully musicians listen with their ears. You know I'll never forget Al Cohn is probably on that list I played with Al Cohn, he was a favorite, man I loved that guy. And I remember one night we were playing somewhere. Did you know Al or did you ever see him?

MR: I saw him in Rochester years ago.

VL: All right. Al was a very straight looking guy.

MR: Yeah. He looked like a banker or something.

VL: That's my story.

MR: Oh come on.

VL: Somebody said to him, I swear to God, somebody said to him on a break you know, you always get — "Gee you don't look like a jazz musician, you look like a banker." And you know Al was very droll. And he accepted it and he smiled. And he came over to me and he says, "So what does a jazz musician look like?" You know Al. And it's true. They just want you to be — I shouldn't say that — but I guess some of them want, some of the people that come out, they like the B movie down and out I guess.

MR: Um hum. A little anguish. They like to see a little anguish.

VL: Yeah. Some pain you know. Al was great. Oh I loved him. He was —

MR: Now he had — I think I saw him with was it Zoot Sims?

VL: Um hum.

MR: And he had the thing with —

VL: Did you ever talk to —

MR: No.

VL: Oh he told stories about him and Zoot at the Half Note in New York. I was only at that club once and I heard – who did I hear there in the early 60s, like Lennie Tristano or somebody you know. I just happened to be in town. And it was a funny kind of a club that I think you walked in and you walked around the bar but the bandstand was above the bar. So the guys, the bartenders would be beneath you. So they had this thing worked out where he and Zoot and the bartender, this character, would give them drinks and when they were done they had this routine where they would play and they would drop it, drop the glass, and he'd walk by and he would catch it.

MR: Oh cool.

VL: I mean they had this whole thing. I'm sorry I missed — somebody might have filmed it, this whole choreography of the drinks going back and forth.

MR: That's neat.

VL: Yeah.

MR: What about Benny Carter?

VL: I played with him on two occasions. I played a weekend with him at Yoshi's — or maybe more. Mel Martin, the saxophone player from the area, put together some stuff for Benny and there was — one was a big band gig right around the corner here at a place called Bimbo's. And he put together a big band so we played Benny's big band book and he was, is, just you talk about somebody that wouldn't fit the mold of a tortured jazz musician, this is a real class act. Benny is a composer, a film writer, and he's — I think one of his mottos is always go first class. Ask Phil Woods. He says that. And he does. And he doesn't settle for less and he's impeccable. And he plays that way. He plays so beautifully. And it was one of those situations where you know you're in the presence of a master. Dizzy's like that and people like that.

MR: You treasure that moment for sure.

VL: Exactly. But that's Benny Carter. And his music of course is without saying, some of the most beautiful music in the world.

MR: Yeah, it's interesting, being with a guy like that, you think about his history being in Europe back in the 30s. What kind of experiences he's had.

VL: Yeah. And like he just came through it with flying colors. He just never lost his class. People are so respectful and deservedly so. And it's a lesson. You don't have to be anything other than a classy individual.

MR: Yeah. Milt Hinton too. Guys like that.

VL: Milt Hinton. My first recording he was on.

MR: No kidding.

VL: Yeah. Carmen Cavallaro.

MR: Oh my God.

VL: Yeah. I was with Carmen Cavallaro for a year, at 18, and hanging on by the skin of my teeth you know. Because it was demanding. It wasn't a real jazz gig but it was like he carried a quartet. I mean piano, bass, drums and guitar. He carried three other musicians beside himself. And he had a show and he played very flashy kind of piano but tempos and styles and I had to come up with that stuff. And so I was with him maybe six months and we were in New York, he lived in New York and we used to spend a lot of time there. And he was recording for Decca. And he had a record date and I was going to be on it and the guitarist who was also a New Yorker but he wasn't going to use the bass

player, he was in between bass players, so I showed up at this studio and they delivered the bass and I look and the tag said Milt Hinton. I went oh my God. I was scared to death anyway. I was just petrified you know. But Milt Hinton, and he came in and just guided me right through it. He was like Benny Carter. This real classy guy and he knew what he was dealing with. He had this 18-year-old frightened kid and I just kept my eye on him and he just guided me right through it. And so that's my first record.

MR: That's a great story. This would have been sixty what?

VL: '61. Yeah. Were you born yet?

MR: Oh yeah. I have to get your date of birth by the way, for my records.

VL: Okay.

[can I use the bathroom]

MR: Absolutely, just unclip yourself. Tim we're taking a little pause here. What is your date of birth, I'll just write it down.

VL: September 23, 1942.

[pause]

VL: Am I allowing you to talk enough?

MR: Yes, I'm having a field day here.

VL: Eddie's cool, you'll have fun with Eddie. Eddie Marshall?

MR: Yeah? I hope so.

VL: Oh he's great.

MR: He said he was going to drive here, and I was a little — I mean I don't know the guy but he's ninety-some, right?

VL: Oh, no, I thought you said—

MR: Oh Eddie Marshall.

VL: No, no Eddie Alley, he's together. But Eddie Marshall. Yeah he's cool.

MR: I was looking at your list also and a fellow I listened to a lot too was John Handy. I see you played with him too.

VL: He lives here.

MR: He lives here.

VL: Yeah. John has been here for years in San Francisco, and then he's moved to Oakland oh three or four years ago. And he's great, John.

MR: Is he still playing?

VL: Oh yeah. He's not out as much you know. But he's playing. He has a group that I used to play with on occasion, it's called Class, it's himself and a rhythm section and three or four violinists, female violinists. I don't know that that has anything to do with it but it probably does.

MR: Let's put it this way, it's not a negative in selling it.

VL: No, but they're obviously competent musicians because John is a very competent musician. And I love John, I love being around him, I love playing with him and he's a teacher. John is a real natural teacher. So people are like that, when you get on the bandstand or rehearse, the way they go about it. And I have the utmost respect for him and I've learned a lot being around him and I've had a lot of fun and playing with him is always exciting, he's very spontaneous, he can be. And of course he's got a pretty good history too, with Mingus and all that.

MR: That's right.

VL: But yeah, John, he's around. Did you think about getting together with him?

MR: I looked for him.

VL: I can give you the number for him.

MR: I'd love to get his number. Probably it's a little late this trip. I'll have to force myself to come back here.

VL: He'd be a good one, yeah.

MR: And Bobby Hutcherson also, I was trying to get him.

VL: Another treasure, oh. See we're lucky around here. Donald Bailey is here. Do you know who Donald Bailey is?

MR: Sure.

VL: Yeah, Donald Bailey lives in Oakland. You know these are my heroes these guys. And they're right here.

MR: Is there, or has there been, any issue with racial tensions between musicians here or audiences or anything like that over the years?

VL: Well I mean I think it exists everywhere to a subtle degree. But I think it's easier here than it is in a lot of places as far as musicians working with each other — black musicians and white musicians working together. It's not an issue, to tell the truth, it's just not. There are so-called cliques everywhere, people that have people they like to play with, and that exists here just like it does everywhere, and sometimes it seems to be an exclusive black clique or an exclusive white clique. But I don't think that that's — it wasn't set up that way it's just the way it happens because people like to play — but I mean I worked with a lot of different races. I mean black people, I worked with John Handy, I worked with Vernon Alley, I mean it's not as — what's the word — as overt as it is — I've talked to people in New York apparently it's a little more lined, you know, divisive.

MR: Is there an Asian influence in the music here?

VL: Yeah, oh yeah. There's, of course we're on the edge of the Pacific you know.

MR: Right.

VL: There are, in fact there's an Asian festival here, a jazz festival, and there are musicians. I haven't played with that many. It's more sort of avante garde, and I'm just a straight ahead spang-a-lang. And that's another thing. You just can — I do what I do. And I appreciate all kinds of music but I do what I do, I'm just not going to spread myself that thin and try to do everything just to say I could do it.

MR: Right.

VL: But there was a musician that, he passed a few years ago, a great, great pianist named Flip Nunez, a Filipino. And I used to work a lot with him and he was really good, played with Jon Hendricks and a lot of different people around here in the sixties and seventies. And then there was another one, a Filipino musician I played a lot with named George Mirabis, another pianist, a great musician. So there is of course Latin musicians, a lot of big Latin musicians, so it's pretty diverse around here.

MR: What's your opinion of smooth jazz?

VL: Well I don't know where they got the name. It's like sometimes we play, you know you play somewhere and you're playing and it's like it's got this kind of seamless, flawless quality to it. And you might be playing someplace and it might be — I mean as jazz musicians we work, I mean I play weddings, I play — but I play the way I play, I'm not going to play — if you want funk or this or that then you get those guys, you don't get me. Sometimes we play and it's like real sort of subdued and quiet. After the tune's over I'll look at the guys and I said, "If this ain't smooth jazz I'll kiss your ass." So I don't know. It's a style of music. I like hearing tunes and chord changes and things like, that's all. I mean I suppose if I grew up in a different time I could be doing that. I think about the kids, when I deal with kids, I see kids with spiked hair and they've got everything going for them and I think well if I was 16 that's probably where I'd be. Right? I mean how can you not look at it that way. So I feel that way about styles of music. But it's not for me. Like I said I like acoustic instruments. It seems to me that smooth jazz or whatever that type of music is is mostly electric bass, electric keyboards. I like acoustic sounding instruments. So leave it there.

MR: If you were going to be stranded on a beach — where did you go to interview school — I don't pull this question out often. I'll just say do you have three or four recordings that just are —

VL: That I've worn out?

MR: That you've worn out?

VL: Yeah. "Monk at the Five Spot" with Johnny Griffin. Ray Charles with I guess part of the record is Quincy Jones and part of the record is —

MR: Betty Carter?

VL: No, no. God. The arranger. I'm blanking here. The guy that wrote "Early Autumn." Oh this is terrible.

MR: Oh I know who you mean too and I can't. Ralph?

VL: Yeah.

MR: Isn't that awful. We'll both think of it later. Ralph Burns.

VL: Ralph Burns. That record. It's a great record. You know that's two, you want five right?

MR: Well.

VL: All right. "Trane Ballads" I love that record, that band, I got to hear that band here in San Francisco, Elvin and McCoy and Jimmy Garrison, Trane. And I've got to put some Miles in there, which one? Maybe "Milestones." Is that the one with "Billy Boy?"

MR: Yes it is and the tune called "Miles." [scats]. I love that record.

VL: No Miles' tunes, I know that tune, the record I'm thinking of is the one with Trane and Philly Joe and they do trio stuff with Red Garland I guess, but they do "Salt Peanuts" I think and stuff like that. Anyway, any of that stuff. God it would be hard to pick one. Aw there's so many, and Duke. "Duke at Newport" I guess would be the — but "Duke at Newport" is — I mean if you wanted, if someone says what is swing? What is swinging? Just put on "Duke at Newport." Put on "Dimenuendo and Crescendo in Blue" with Paul Gonsalves and Sam Woodyard back there.

MR: Right.

VL: That's swinging. And I don't know maybe Sinatra "Only the Lonely" or something like that. Beautiful stuff. I mean there are just too many.

MR: What about, do your tastes go into — who do you like in the pop world, anyone in particular?

VL: Like right now?

MR: Yeah.

VL: I don't find myself in that arena very often. God. Who have I heard that I like? There must be somebody out there. I really can't think of anybody.

MR: I know I don't listen to it that much myself.

VL: If you're talking about other styles of music, James Brown of course and Aretha, and James Taylor I like. I really dig James Taylor. Every now and then I'll see him on something and I think I like this guy.

MR: Yeah. And he always has a great band too.

VL: Yeah. But it's just kind of folksy, but it's not. It's more. And I don't know just out of the blue, stuff that I think is cool.

MR: I have one more piece of music that you're on here. See if you recognize—
[audio interlude]

VL: Yeah. Tania, Tania Maria. Is this "Yatra-ta?"

MR: Yeah, that's cooking.

VL: Okay. This, interesting story. I'm with Cal Tjader, right? Probably '80 or thereabouts, '81. And Carl Jefferson, who is Concord Records, calls and said, "I want you to do this, we're going to do a record with a Brazilian piano player singer that I just signed and no one ever knew about it." And I said, "Okay." So he hired Cal's — me, Cal's drummer and bass player, Rob Fisher. And — is Poncho on that? Is Poncho on that do you know? I don't have the liner note with me. It's either Poncho or a local conga player named Willie, a conga drummer named Willie Colon.

MR: I think it's Willie Colon.

VL: Willie Colon. Okay, not Willie Colon the New York trombone player. Yeah I don't think Poncho did this. Anyway so we show up at the Coast Recorders and Tania is there and we meet her and she speaks very little English. And no rehearsal or anything we're just in the studio and getting ready to do this thing. And so nothing is written out. And she says, I mean well let's hear what you're going to do. So she launches into this tune, this first tune, and we all looked at each other like what are we gonna do my God? I mean this whole thing that she had worked out. And we just worked it out and recorded it. And that's how it came out. But the panic look on everybody's face, we're in the studio and we're going to make this record, and that was it. After a few mis-runs or whatever you want to call them, we came up with that. And got through it somehow, and the rest of the record — oh Eddie Duran's on that, the guitarist, he's on there. And but that was the first thing we did and of course I think that was the hardest thing, which is good, get that out of the way. But it was like oh my God I'm in deep do-do now. But she is great. I mean boy. You're talking about —

MR: What happened to her is she still around?

VL: She was, let's see, when I met her she was living in Paris I think. And she's from Brazil. And she lived in Paris. And then she moved here shortly after and lived in I guess lived in New York for many years, for quite a few years. And now I understand she's back in Europe. I'm not sure where. But I mean I sort of kept track, when she would come through town, she got more into like a Latin funk thing, pop Latin funk. And she could do that. She was really something. I mean I was awed by her. She's got a lot of talent you know. But that what we did there was probably the jazziest thing she ever — I mean with acoustic instruments, you know what I mean, that kind of thing. But that was, boy you talk about the look on our faces when she launched into that it was oh my God.

MR: That's cool. Desperation leads to inspiration.

VL: Well I guess. But the thing is, it's one thing to be at a rehearsal and be in trouble. But to be at a recording studio, and because the clock is ticking, it's like you feel this pressure. But it really came out pretty good I thought in retrospect. It's like wow.

MR: Well it sure caught my ear, because I was sitting down with this record thinking I wanted to bring a little excerpt here. And that was the one that popped out.

VL: Yeah, record. I notice you said record.

MR: Record. Yes. Right.

VL: Yeah. I'm on records. Vinyl.

MR: Yeah. Isn't that something. Well what's your view on the state of jazz these days? Do you have an opinion on where it's at?

VL: Well I mean there's so many things happening in different directions and the record industry is very strange. I mean CDs, the recording industry, it's almost out of hand it seems like with people — you go to Tower Records which is right here and it's overwhelming in the product that's out there. And everybody's — and this thing about copying and burning CDs, I mean I feel sorry for people that are just trying to get in there. I mean I'm not trying to get — I'm content to be a sideman or just play gigs and just keep playing. As long as I'm playing with good guys it's fine, I'm happy. I front my own things on occasion. But it's really spread out now, which is good. I mean I guess it's healthy that it's not the same thing, it can't stay the same way you know. I like playing swinging music and that's not going to change. But there's so many influences now that didn't exist or predominate, the world music influences and the pop and like everything else, a lot of music or a lot of dominant culture music is aimed at a certain age group and you go to a movie and it's car chases and decapitations. And it's got to be aimed at somebody. Not me. And I think that music is like that. And the state of jazz, these guys are getting better. I'll tell you, the level of musicianship, or the level of technicality of people playing an instrument has gone up considerably from when I was starting out. I've got kids that are 17 and 18 that I teach in high schools that play a bunch of stuff that I can't even comprehend practically. And so that part is, and it reflects all the instruments. You hear these kids with saxophones and keyboards and playing all over the instrument. But like everything else with maturity that starts to get better I think. I think that I'm mature so I can appreciate more. But I don't know I don't dwell on it, about the old days or this or that, I just keep doing what you're doing. As long as I'm healthy and doing what I'm doing it's fine. I play with some younger people. This big band I play with I could, I'm everybody's father, I could be a grandfather in a couple of instances. I mean I'm going to be 60 next month and there are kids in there that are in their twenties so I guess I could be a grandfather. And I'm playing —

MR: Yeah, all of a sudden you're the elder statesman.

VL: Yeah they open doors for me.

MR: Yeah. You're the Milt Hinton.

VL: Yeah. Give me a chair you know.

MR: There could be advantage to that, carrying your drums in and out.

VL: I'm going to milk it, believe me. You know I'm married to a musician, I'm married to a singer. I don't know if you knew that, Madeline Eastman, a real good singer. And that works good. We are not the typical husband-wife work together all the time you know. We do but we don't and it works fine. We keep it that way. Like a lot of husband wife teams are the Bickersons on stage, you know what I mean? "It's too fast, it's too slow, wrong key." We get a kick out of that.

MR: You counted it off.

VL: Yeah, right.

MR: Well this has been a real pleasure for me.

VL: Same here. Same here. Early in the morning, once we get going, it just gets going. Fortunately I live down the street, I'm two blocks away, which is real cool.

MR: Well great, I hope I see you at Pearl's maybe before we leave.

VL: Yeah I'm trying to think, I'll be there tonight with a saxophone player from L.A., a guy named Bruce Escovitz, who happens to be teaching at the Stanford Jazz Workshop. I saw him yesterday. And so he's playing with us — us being a kind of put together rhythm section. And then the weekend, I don't know who's there this weekend, but there's always good music there. And talk to the guy that runs the joint, Sonny Buxton, a very interesting man. He's got his own radio show on Saturdays. You might catch him Saturday between ten and two on KCSM 91.1. He's got a good show.

MR: Great. All right well thanks for your time today.

VL: All right you're welcome. Thank you.